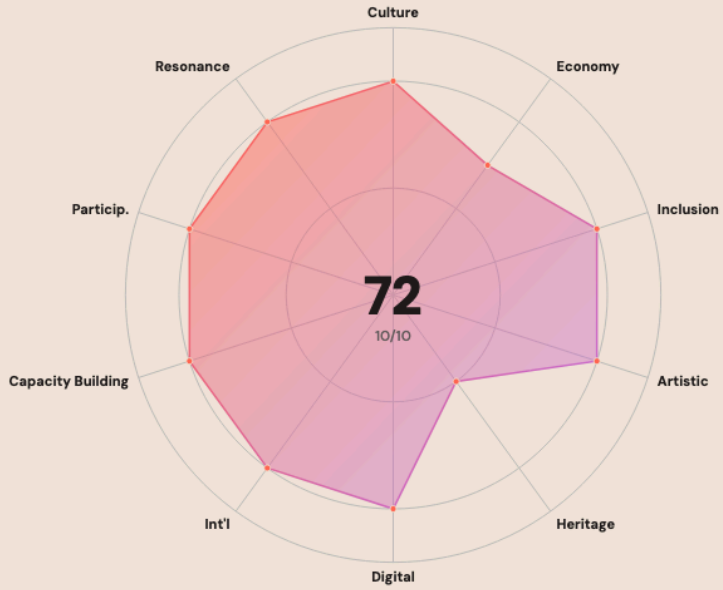
Notations Laboratory & Showcase: Interdisciplinary Sound and Heritage Festival



PROPOSAL SUMMARY

A two-week interdisciplinary laboratory and festival held in Yerevan, Armenia, bringing together sound artists, musicians, visual artists, and performers to explore the intersection of Armenian classical heritage and contemporary experimental practice. The program included workshops on performance theory, folk recordings as digital instruments, and notation systems, alongside collaborative creation sessions that resulted in new works, installations, and music releases. With 1,000 on-site and 2 million online participants, the project fostered international artistic exchange and strengthened Armenia's emerging cultural infrastructure. Key outcomes included an album based on Armenian Khaz notation research, collaborative installations at the State Philharmonia, and expanded professional networks connecting Armenian artists with European cultural policy frameworks.

CRITERIA SCORES

SORTED BY SCORE DESC

1	Cultural Vitality	4/5
3	Social Inclusion	4/5
4	Artistic Quality	4/5
6	Digitality	4/5
7	Internationality	4/5
8	Capacity Building	4/5
9	Participation	4/5
10	Resonance	4/5
2	Creative Economy	3/5
5	Heritage & Environment	2/5

1. Cultural Vitality

●●●●○ 4/5

- ● Strong cultural originality with documented boundary-breaking outcomes (improvisation firsts, cross-disciplinary work, architectural mapping innovation)
- ● Concrete artifact linking Armenian heritage research (Khaz notation) to contemporary output (album)
- ● Multiple local partnerships with named Armenian artists and organizations embedded in ecosystem
- ● Structured research methodology (observe-research-implement) applied to laboratory design

- ○ Audience needs and cultural problem not explicitly articulated beyond infrastructure gaps
- ○ Co-authorship power dynamics and formal partnership structures not documented
- ○ Research sources and step-by-step process documentation missing
- ○ Contextual claims about Armenian music sector lack supporting data or citations

2. Creative Economy

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- ● Strong market integration with proven distribution (Bandcamp release) and exceptional digital reach (2M online audience)
- ● Demonstrated financial execution capacity with $120k budget and delivered commercial outputs
- ● Active engagement with innovative remuneration and funding frameworks through policy research

- ○ No documented employment creation or paid roles despite significant project scale
- ○ Financial sustainability model unclear beyond immediate project completion
- ○ Financial innovation remains conceptual without implemented mechanisms

3. Social Inclusion

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- ● Exceptional community co-creation with participant-initiated collaborations and public outputs
- ● Strong participant agency and empowerment across artistic disciplines
- ● Meaningful multicultural engagement bridging Armenian heritage with international practice
- ● Bilingual operation with diverse international participation

- ○ No documented accessibility provisions for physical, economic, or digital access
- ○ Missing explicit mechanisms to address marginalization beyond artistic roles
- ○ Limited evidence of multilingual outputs or systematic cultural mediation
- ○ No safeguards against tokenism or power-sharing in governance

4. Artistic Quality

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- ● Strong execution of contemporary forms with multiple realized outputs (installation, mapping, digital release)
- ● Clear curatorial methodology with documented participant transformation
- ● Credible team with institutional partnerships and realized collaborations
- ● Policy-focused critical discourse integrated into laboratory structure

- ○ Missing comprehensive curatorial text or published artistic rationale
- ○ Incomplete team documentation (full roster, CVs, formal commitments)
- ○ Limited evidence of critical discourse beyond participant experience
- ○ No published critical essays or confirmed public debate outcomes

5. Heritage & Environment

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- ● Concrete heritage research outputs: Khaz notation album demonstrates structured engagement with Armenian intangible heritage
- ● Methodological approach to folk recordings transformation provides replicable framework for heritage digitization
- ● Multiple heritage artifacts produced (album, installation) show research translated into public-facing work

- ○ No documented partnerships with heritage institutions or formal research protocols
- ○ Site meaningfulness not articulated: venue used as container rather than meaningful place
- ○ Environmental sustainability completely absent from project conception and execution
- ○ No evidence of permissions, community consultation, or ethical frameworks for heritage work

6. Digitality

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- ● Strong multi-platform digital presence with completed artifacts (Bandcamp, YouTube, Google Drive)
- ● Technological innovation through architectural mapping and digital instrument development
- ● Real-time interactive performance components demonstrated
- ● Accessible distribution through established platforms

- ○ Limited documentation of R&D processes and technical specifications
- ○ Absence of detailed UX/onboarding strategies for digital channels
- ○ No evidence of sustained user participation loops or data-driven feedback mechanisms
- ○ Claimed 2M online audience lacks supporting access metrics or distribution detail

7. Internationality

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- ● Strong international partner participation with confirmed artists from Georgia, Russia, China, Germany, Italy
- ● Deep multi-cultural representation evidenced through co-created outputs (installations, albums, collaborations)
- ● Transformative cross-cultural exchange demonstrated through documented practice shifts and co-production structures

- ○ Transferability remains conceptual with no concrete replication design or documented pilots
- ○ No evidence of modular packaging or adaptation toolkit for other contexts
- ○ Generic claims about global applicability without specific transfer mechanisms

8. Capacity Building

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- ● Exceptional skill transfer outcomes with multiple documented cases of participants acquiring new competencies and producing concrete works
- ● Strong educational design with confirmed expert instructors and structured pedagogical approaches across disciplines
- ● Demonstrated ecosystem impact beyond immediate participants, with ripple effects into broader Armenian cultural infrastructure

- ○ Institutional partnerships lack formal agreements or defined long-term roles beyond the laboratory period
- ○ No evidence of governance, community infrastructure, or funding mechanisms to sustain activity without continuous new grants
- ○ Post-laboratory continuity relies on individual momentum rather than structural support systems

9. Participation

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- ● Exceptional active engagement evidenced by participant breakthroughs (first improvisation, cross-disciplinary creation)
- ● Strong cross-disciplinary inclusivity allowing artists to work outside habitual roles
- ● Structured participatory formats (Round Robin, Total Jam) with documented creative momentum

- ○ Dialogue depth not evidenced beyond session descriptions; no documented feedback loops or published outputs
- ○ Process transparency weak: internal structure exists but not communicated publicly or to participants
- ○ Inclusivity limited to skill-set diversity; no evidence of broader accessibility measures

10. Resonance

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- ● Exceptional media traction with 2M online reach and comprehensive documentation assets
- ● Strong institutional validation through State Philharmonia, Moscow Conservatory, and EU Parliament involvement
- ● Proven continuation through released album and documented organizational interest in outputs
- ● Clear productization strategy with 7-release series and international network pathways

- ○ No evidence of risk mitigation protocols despite documented boundary-crossing activities
- ○ Absence of communication strategy for managing experimental elements with traditional institutions
- ○ No documented preparedness for potential professional discomfort or criticism